

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

IN A DIFFERENT LEAGUE

Following AAP's massive victory in Punjab, there was speculation that the party could be the new pivot around which an Opposition alliance coalesces. The Opposition parties, though, are still to warm up to the contender. Not a single top leader among them, including Congress's Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi, state chief ministers Mamata Banerjee, M.K. Stalin and Uddhav Thackeray, NCP chief Sharad Pawar, SP's Akhilesh Yadav, posted the customary congratulatory tweet. That said, despite the political hostilities, Prime Minister Narendra Modi was quick to take to Twitter to congratulate AAP the day the election results came out.



No Upper Berths?

Before the scheduled organisational polls to elect the next Congress president, the grand ol' party faces another crisis—ensuring Rajya Sabha berths for party veterans. In April, **Anand Sharma** and A.K. Antony will retire, in June, the tenure of **Jairam Ramesh** and Vivek Tankha gets over. The list for July includes Kapil Sibal and Ambika Soni. While Antony has already announced that he will not seek re-election, the party is unlikely to field Sharma and Sibal—two members of the rebel group in the party. The fate of Soni and Ramesh is uncertain as the party doesn't have the numbers in the states. By July, the current Congress tally in the upper house, 34, will see a further decline.

–Kaushik Deka with Romita Datta, Anilesh S. Mahajan and Rahul Noronha

ZERO MASS GAME



The crushing defeat of **Balbir Singh Rajewal**, the anchor of the farm union protests, shows that though the unions get the people's support on issues, they are still not seen as political alternatives. And it isn't just Rajewal who lost his deposit, 93 of the 94 candidates put up by the Sanyukt Samaj Morcha were in the same boat. Some 22 of the 32 farmers' unions that had taken part in the year-long agitation had come together to form the newly minted party. Guess it's back to the fields for the men.

The Cadre Inheritors





In a first in Madhya Pradesh, and perhaps the country, the son and daughter of the state's chief secretary and DGP are serving in the same state cadre and under the same service. Chief secretary **Iqbal Singh Bains**'s son Amanbir, a 2013 batch IAS officer, is currently collector of Betul. DGP **Sudhir Saxena**'s daughter, Sonakshi, a 2020 batch IPS officer, is a probationer at Indore. So, does having daddy as top boss make it easier, work-wise? The verdict isn't out yet.

OUTSIDER, INSIDER

The Trinamool Congress (TMC) has pitched two ex-BJP MPs, **Babul Supriyo** and **Shatrughan Sinha**, as their candidates for the Vidhan Sabha and Lok Sabha by-polls respectively. The BJP is euphoric and is already using Mamata's own "outsider" tag against both. While this sits pretty on Bihari babu Sinha, the same can't be said for Supriyo, who is a Bengali to the core. But the BJP has its own logic: both are outsiders in the sense that they are not from the TMC stable. The BJP, sources say, plans to use the outsider jingle to make the insiders (the original Trinamool acolytes) ponder the lack of returns after staying with the party for so long.

